

Syria

On October 8th, 2002, the United States government subjected Maher Arar, a Syrian-born Canadian citizen to an extraordinary rendition to Syria. NYPD officials and other U.S officials collaborated to detain, question, and extradite Mr. Arar due to his alleged ties with the terrorist group known as al Qaeda. Once arriving in Syria, Mr. Arar was brutally beaten and interrogated by the Syrian government and forced to live in a small underground cell. After a year of this torture, Mr. Arar was released by Syria without ever being charged with a crime. The New York Police Department played an active role in the unconstitutional interrogation and wrongful extradition of Maher Arar to Syria.

On September 28th, 2002, Maher Arar arrived at JFK airport for a layover on his trip from Tunisia, where he was on vacation, to his home country of Canada. While at JFK airport, Mr. Arar was taken aside by immigration officials where he was questioned, fingerprinted, and searched. For eight hours, Maher Arar was interrogated by immigration officials and New York City Police Department Intelligence Division detectives. During this interrogation, Mr. Arar was not given access to a lawyer and was not told why he was being questioned. Two days later, Mr. Arar was taken to the Metropolitan Detention Center for continued interrogation and was asked to “voluntarily” return to Syria - a country that he had not been to since the age of seventeen. Mr. Arar refused, citing that he was worried he would be tortured if he returned to Syria.

On October 1st, 2002 Mr. Arar was told by immigration officials that he was not allowed to enter the United States because of his alleged connection to the terrorist group al Qaeda. No proof of this connection was ever shown to Mr. Arar and he completely denies any involvement with the group. On October 3rd, 2002 a Canadian consulate official spoke to him at MDC and promised him that he would not be sent to Syria because he is a Canadian citizen.

A week later on October 8th, 2002 Mr. Arar was flown to Jordan and then sent to Syria. After arriving in Syria, Maher Arar was interrogated, beaten, and whipped with an electrical cable. He was forced to listen to other people be tortured and was forced to confess that he was trained by terrorists in Afghanistan. Mr. Arar denies that he has any connection to terrorists, but out of fear for his life he falsely confessed. Though never confirmed by the U.S government, Mr. Arar alleged that his interrogations in Syria were coordinated with U.S. officials. From October 8th, 2002 to October 3rd, 2003 Mr. Arar was forced to live in a grave-like underground cell. After a year of this treatment, Mr. Arar was released without being charged and returned to Canada to reunite with his wife and children.

Citations:

Center for Constitutional Rights, n.d. 'Maher Arar: Rendition to Torture'. Available at [https://ccrjustice.org/sites/default/files/assets/rendition to torture report.pdf](https://ccrjustice.org/sites/default/files/assets/rendition%20to%20torture%20report.pdf) (Accessed October 15 2024).

Department of Homeland Security Office of the Attorney General, 2008 'The Removal of a Canadian Citizen to Syria' *Department of Homeland Security*. Available at [https://www.oig.dhs.gov/sites/default/files/assets/PDFs/The Removal of a Canadian Citizen to Syria \(Redacted\).pdf](https://www.oig.dhs.gov/sites/default/files/assets/PDFs/The%20Removal%20of%20a%20Canadian%20Citizen%20to%20Syria%20(Redacted).pdf) (Accessed October 15 2024)